In: Combating Islamic Militancy and Terrorism…
Editor: Nikolas J. Koppel
ISBN: 978-1-60741-335-6
© 2010 Nova Science Publishers, Inc.

Chapter 1

ISLAMIST MILITANCY IN THE PAKISTAN-AFGHANISTAN BORDER REGION AND U.S. POLICY*

K. Alan Kronstadt and Kenneth Katzman

SUMMARY

Increasing militant activityin western Pakistan poses three keynational security threats: an increased potential for major attacks against the United States itself; a growing threat to Pakistani stability; and a hindrance of U.S. efforts to stabilize Afghanistan. This report will be updated as events warrant.

A U.S.-Pakistan relationship marked byperiods of both cooperation and discord was transformed by the September 2001 terrorist attacks on the United States and the ensuing enlistment of Pakistan as a key ally in U.S.-led counterterrorism efforts. Top U.S. officials have praised Pakistan for its ongoing cooperation, although long-held doubts exist about Islamabad's commitment to some core U.S. interests. Pakistan is identified as a base for terrorist groups and their supporters operating in Kashmir, India, and Afghanistan. Since 2003, Pakistan's army has conducted unprecedented and largely ineffectual counterterrorism operations in the country's Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) bordering Afghanistan, where Al Qaeda operatives and pro-Taliban insurgents are said to enjoy "safe haven." Militant groups have only grown stronger and more aggressive in 2008. Islamabad's new civilian-led government vows to combat militancy in the FATA through a combination of military force, negotiation with "reconcilable" elements, and economic development. The Pakistani military has in late 2008 undertaken major operations aimed at neutralizing armed extremism in the Bajaur agency, and the government is equipping local tribal militias in several FATA agencies with the hope that these can supplement efforts to bring the region under more effective state writ.

Copyright © 2010. Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated. All rights reserved.

* This is an edited, reformatted and augmented version of a CRS Report for Congress publication dated November 2008.

Combating Islamic Militancy and Terrorism in Pakistan's Border Region, Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated, 2010. ProQuest Ebook Central,